Critical Analysis of Interfaces

Platform: Netmeds | Domain: Online Pharmacy / E-Pharmacy

Introduction

Netmeds is an online pharmacy service where customers can order prescription and non-prescription drugs, schedule their lab tests and purchase numerous health and personal care products. As far as one examines the web-site he or she will notice that it incorporates a design that touches on numerous aspects. Such a feature of the service can be considered a benefit and a drawback as well. With regard to the ease of use of the interface the key search bar is easy to locate. However, the presence of various menu options on the top line is quite an excessive element of the interface. It includes medicines, lab tests, make-up products, perfumes, pet supplies and surgical supplies. Such a variety of options is too much for a person using the web-site or the app for the first time prior to conducting any searches. Searching for a particular drug in the web-site is easy however, the results of an additional research showed that due to the nature of the web-site structure there are certain site UI issues. Such issues include site design, placement of various elements and other similar features. The site consistency is not proper. There is a prescription warning message that comes times consecutively on the home page, and it looks like it is repetitive thing instead of giving single clear message. So there are some UI improvement that needs to be done in Netmeds site to have a good user experience.

Parameter Based Analysis

Parameter	Netmeds Analysis
Learnability	As a whole, the design looks like a pharmacy website and makes it easy for users to find a search bar even if they visit the site for the first time. On the other hand, the menu at the top is filled with all kinds of categories (they were checked directly at the site). There are just too many of them before a user starts his/her search: Medicine, Beauty, Hair, Mens Grooming, Make-Up, Mom & Baby Wellness Ayush, Fitness, Sexual Wellness, Diabetes Support, Devices, Surgical, Eyewear, Veterinary and others.
Usability	The search of medications is quite simple in terms of theory. The research of redesign was conducted separately from this project in order to change the "navigation flow" and "visual elements". This means that the navigation and visual flow of this website have some flaws.
Consistency	The message about the necessity to have a prescription is presented several times at the home page (it was checked directly at the site). Whatever it may be, an error or not, it looks like several messages rather than just one.

Use of Metaphors	Categories as well as the cart are created according to e-commerce principles. However, I could not check the cart, trash and other menu icons as the page provided only text labels.
Navigation Structure	The only criterion that I managed to check personally is the mega-menu organization. In this menu categories and subcategories (Beauty> Fragrances/Hair/Make-Up Wellness Ayush>Ayurvedic/Unani/Homeopathy/Siddha) are combined together in one huge list, from which it is not possible to differentiate primary ones from secondary ones. The mega-menu includes basic elements of pharmacy – medicines, laboratory tests as well as retail elements.
Visual Hierarchy	Website layout (banners, product cards) can be not assessed as the page is provided only with text-navigation and footers.After considering the no. of categories in the menu, it is possible to assume that there must be some contradiction between primary pharmacy aims and retail aims; however, I cannot prove that without having any real website layout.
Accessibility	In the research of the website's redesign it was mentioned that one of the goals of the development is accessibility of the website for everyone, which means that it might be the case that something is missing from the current layout (reported, but not verified by me personally).
Responsiveness	Since the website does not allow testing the functionality of the menu on different screens, I did not manage to evaluate the criterion.
Efficiency of Interaction	A UX study noted that users needed to switch between applications or sections in order to contact a doctor, schedule reminders and adhere to a health plan (reported). That means the user's health-related activities are split between different locations and not integrated into one seamless location alongside the main purchasing process.
Feedback and System Status	The problem mentioned in multiple reviews is deliveries marked as "delivered" while not being delivered (reported by many people). It is a straight violation of the interface's requirements to show the accurate status of the delivery regardless of the reasons behind it.
Error Prevention and Recovery	There is one report of a case when booking a laboratory test there were discrepancies related to wrong packaging for a certain gender and no additional confirmation steps taken before ordering (reported, one case).
Aesthetic and Minimalistic Design	The top menu lists everything from perfumes and makeup tools to veterinary and surgical items in one list making it look more like a general shop than a pharmacy, which goes against a clean simple look.

Content Readability	Top navigation contains a lot of elements starting with perfumes and makeup accessories and ending with veterinary and surgical supplies – all listed in one place which makes the website look rather general than pharmaceutical.checked.
Search and Discoverability	A broad and extensive category tree works effectively for an individual when they already know what they are looking for while a case study of separate features (doctor visits, reminders, health plans) indicates that these non-purchase related elements are more difficult to discover than the actual products (reported).
Performance Perception	The loading time of webpages, loading procedure, and transitions were not provided; I was unable to find out this information myself.
Trust and Credibility	There are lots of items in the footer which are intended to increase the level of trust to the website. These items include Terms and Conditions, Privacy Policy, Editorial Policy, and Caution Notice. The thing is that the people who have visited this website before claim that it provides inaccurate information regarding delivery date and also it complicates refunding process. It means that the website considers itself to be trustworthy. However, the situation is quite opposite as it can be seen from the Trustpilot and Google reviews. The information about delivery status is inaccurate and refunding is complicated. It means that people do not see the website as being trustworthy.
Personalization	There were no personalization features on the homepage that I managed to grab, though it should be said that this might be caused by the fact that the content with personalization features is dynamically loaded, hence, this lack of information can be considered as uncertain.
User Satisfaction	Aggregated reviews from sources are mostly negative but most of the problems people have are about how fast the items arrive and how helpful the support team is, not, about the way the app looks or works. If we look at the way the app is designed some studies where the app was completely redesigned show that there is still a lot that can be done to make it easier to find things and to make different parts of the app work better together.. The app isn't completely broken or hard to use.

Overall UI/UX Problems Identified

- The number of menu items is quite a lot, and thus it becomes really difficult to locate the needed stuff when it comes to medicines.
- The website does not correlate well. The elements such as consults with the doctor, taking of medication, and the health plans are located independently.
- On the main page of website you will see the prescription warning repeatedly.

- When you order medicine the website does not always tell you the information about when it will arrive.
- When you first go to the website it does not seem to know much about you.
- When you are using the website to do things like choose a lab test it does not always make sure that you have made the choices.

Strongest UX Features

- There are different sections for all types of pharmacies and health-related content on the website. In this case, the user can easily find what he needs when knowing it.
- The footer of the website is well-explained. There are special sections which show the essential links for the user such as terms and conditions, privacy policy, shipping, etc. In this case, users can see the policies of the websites.
- There are warnings about the need for prescriptions while looking through the medicines categories. It means that users will keep in mind the rules.
- The first thing you see after visiting the website is the search box. In this way, the user can easily find the needed medicine.

Most Important Problem to Solve

There are some notable disadvantages in the structure of the menu that appears on the company's website. And it is important to research this topic, because we are aware of its existence and its influence on such issues as convenience of use, organization, user perception, presentation of the site and amount of information that users need to remember.

For the research of the current situation we are going to conduct categorization research when the participants will be asked to group menu items and then develop prototypes of the menu. For the testing of the prototype we are going to conduct task-based research when the users will be asked to find and order the medicines they usually buy. This research will help us to understand if this menu, that includes all the items on one page, really creates problems for users.

The results of this research will give us the chance to improve the menu on the site bit by bit. Please make sure that the menu is organized properly according to the tasks users do on the site. Mega-menu navigation is the problem we should consider.

Evaluation Using Shneiderman's Golden Rules

Sr. No.	Shneiderman's Golden Rule	Netmeds Evaluation
1.	**Strive for Consistency**	The message concerning the prescriptions is shown times on the homepage; I am sure it

		would be easier for it to have only one message in one place.
2.	**Seek universal ability**	Based on the research, conducted by the experts, the main purpose of the website is to make it accessible to all users, but now this goal is not fulfilled.
3.	**Offer informative feedback**	The most serious issue with this site is that order status is sometimes incorrect, so order may appear as "delivered" even if it is not yet delivered. This issue with the site needs to be fixed.
4.	**Design dialogs to yield closure**	As an example, the booking performed during the test without confirmation raises doubts whether the order was confirmed. The same happens with the case of the lab test mismatch; in this case, the booking passes without confirmation.
5.	**Prevent errors**	It can also be seen from the same test that there is no confirmation made prior to making the final decision, which is an issue.
6.	**Permit easy reversal of actions**	We do not have any information about whether it is easy for users to undo or reverse their order. Reversing the cart or order should be tested using the website.
7.	**Keep users in control**	The website is not user friendly since it has multiple sections which do not work together. In fragmented cross-app/cross-section experience, users themselves need to manage the workflow and not the interface.
8.	**Reduce short term memory load**	The menu on the website is very big. Has many choices, which can be overwhelming. The wide flat mega-menu with dozens of category and sub-category labels asks users to scan and remember options, which is the same issue, with the mega-menu.